

Making plans

A little extra planning is the key to successful travel in pregnancy. Think carefully before you book. How will you get there and how long will it take? Pregnancy adds to the stress of a long-haul trip. If you want to fly, check with the airline about its policy. Some require a current letter from your doctor confirming your due date and your fitness to fly after 36 weeks, largely because of the possibility of going into labor.

Find out about the medical facilities in case you have any health problems while on vacation. Unless you have no choice, avoid visiting countries where disease is a high risk factor. Many doctors agree that protective drugs, such as certain vaccines and antimalarial pills, are not advisable in pregnancy or when trying to conceive. Check the internet for information about an area's health hazards and local hospitals. If you have a condition such as diabetes that could cause complications, make sure you can get treatment while away.

Take out travel insurance. Some companies consider pregnancy a preexisting condition and won't provide coverage for your trip.

ADVANCE PLANNING

You've found your passport and put the tickets in your bag. However, when you're pregnant, you may also need to take the following items:

- A note from your doctor stating your due date and giving you the all-clear to travel (helpful if you're over 28 weeks).
- Any special medical records regarding your pregnancy or general health.
- A list of numbers for health-care facilities at your destination.
- Remedies for heartburn or other minor pregnancy problems, such as hemorrhoids. You may not be able to buy your usual products abroad.

TRIMESTER-BY-TRIMESTER TRAVEL GUIDE

Think about the implications of traveling at different times in your pregnancy when planning a trip.

1st trimester (weeks 1–12)

- Period of highest risk for miscarriage and development problems in the baby. Be extra careful to avoid extremes of temperature and overly vigorous activities.
- Motion sickness could make morning sickness worse.
- Flying is allowed, provided you have no pregnancy complications.
- Insurance is unlikely to be a problem.

2nd trimester (weeks 13–25)

- You are likely to be feeling your best, and the chances of miscarriage or fetal development problems are greatly reduced.
- Flying is allowed, but check to see whether you need to carry a doctor's letter stating your due date.
- Check with individual travel insurance companies to see if you can get coverage—policies vary.

3rd trimester (weeks 26–40)

- Your belly is huge and travel may be very uncomfortable now.
- Some airlines may not allow you to fly after 36 weeks without a letter from your doctor written within 72 hours of your flight that includes your due date and confirms your fitness to fly.